

A

What are fixed phrases?

There are many groups of words which you need to learn as complete phrases, because they often have a meaning which is different from the words on their own. Many of these are called idioms.

They arrived **out of the blue** [I didn't know they were coming; it was unexpected].

Does the name Merchant **ring a bell** [sound familiar]?

You'll have to **make up your mind** soon. [make a decision]

Some fixed phrases are easier to understand, but the same idea may be expressed in a different way in your language.

I think we'll have to **get rid of** some of this furniture.

[remove it, e.g. sell it, throw it away, give it away, etc.]

I'm afraid I can't talk to you now; **I'm (just) about to** leave. [I am going to leave very soon]

I don't know what Martin said, but Natalie **burst into tears** [suddenly started crying]. She was very upset.

Everyone was there **apart from** Yasmine.

[not including Yasmine; *syn* **except for**]



B

Time phrases

He's leaving **in four days' time** [four days from now; also in three weeks'/six months'/two years' time, etc.].

I got here **the week before last** [during the week/month, etc. before the previous one].

The course is fine **so far** [up until now].

I rang our local doctor and fortunately she was able to come **at once** [now, immediately; *syns* **right away** / **straight away**].

He's so busy at work; he comes home late **night after night** [every night; also **day after day**, etc.].

C

Pairs of words

A number of fixed phrases consist of two words, usually joined by **and**, and sometimes **or**.

I go to the theatre **now and again** [occasionally; *syns* **now and then**].

Andy had **one or two** [a few] suggestions.

I've got a house in the country, and I like to go there whenever possible for a bit of **peace and quiet** [a calm situation without noise].

I've been **up and down** the street, but I can't find their house. [first in one direction, then the other]

I've been to Paris **once or twice** [a few times].

I'll finish this report **sooner or later** [I don't know when, but I'll finish it].

D

Introducing advice, opinions, etc.

Many fixed phrases are used to introduce advice, an opinion, an example, etc.

If I were you [in your situation], I'd accept the job they offered you.

In general [usually, or in most situations; *syn* **on the whole**] the summers are quite warm in this part of the country.

There were lots of questions. **For instance** [for example], how much will it cost?

I'm sure you'll have a great holiday. **By the way**, what time does the train leave? (used to introduce a new subject to the conversation)

To be honest, I didn't like her boyfriend very much. (used to say what you really think)